



(LEFT) BALUCH PROTESTERS AT A RALLY IN QUETTA; MANMOHAN WITH GILANI AT SHARM EL-SHEIKH

Sistan province, parts of Afghanistan as well as parts of Sindh and Punjab provinces where Baloch populations reside. It is headed by Allah Nazar since its founder Ghulam Mohammad Baloch was killed in April.

But how much support do these groups actually have? Major General Nawaz estimates that the "hardcore" of all these groups combined is not more than 200 men, assisted by some more hundreds of sympathisers. However, the general perception in Quetta is that large numbers of youth have been radicalised by the continuing military operations in the Marri and Bugti areas, the strong-arm tactics of

security officials such as Major General Nawaz acknowledge that the roots of the problem lie in the alienation of the Baloch. "We should be ashamed that our people should come to a point where they are willing to be used by external interests," he says. "We need to create the political space whereby parties that believe in federal politics can come and assert themselves. And we need to sincerely address the real issues of socio-political dissatisfaction which has led to this stage of frustration."

Most mainstream parties, despite their resentments, believe that being of Baloch ancestry, President Asif Ali Zardari, is sincere about finding a solution to the problems of Balochistan, though they also express doubt at how much real power he and the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP) Chief Minister Sardar Aslam Raisani have to influence the military which they feel controls Balochistan policy. Zardari tasked senior PPP leader Raza Rabbani with putting forward a series of recommendations to address the alienation of Balochistan, and these recommendations have already been presented to the prime minister. Though not yet made public, it is understood that they build on the recommendations of the committee headed by Senator Mushahid Hussain during the previous government and address most of the hot-button issues including more equitable royalty from gas and minerals, greater Baloch control over the Gwadar port, mandatory utilisation of local labour and a greater share in the National Finance Commission award to the province, as well as a special status for the province to spur development.

The separatist groups have already rejected any dialogue with the state and have, in fact, announced they would proclaim an independent Balochistan on August 11. The mainstream parties are mostly hoping that the government announces a package that is dramatic enough to take the wind out of the radicals' sails. Given the intensity of feelings that the issue engenders, the window of opportunity for the government's action is indeed very small. ■



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The other major player in the militancy is Mir Herbiyar Marri, another son of a tribal chieftain Khair Bakhsh Marri, who himself was part of an armed insurgency in the 1970s. Herbiyar, a former provincial minister, is self-exiled in London and is allegedly the head of the Balochistan Liberation Army (BLA)—though he denies it—which operates mainly in the Marri area of Kohlu where the main army operation is being carried out. Herbiyar openly advocates the secession of Balochistan from Pakistan and has called on the West and the United Nations to support his demand for an independent Balochistan.

A third smaller armed group is the Balochistan Liberation Front (BLF) which operates mainly in the southern Mekran region and advocates an independent 'Greater Balochistan' comprising parts of Iran's Balochistan-

the Pakistani intelligence services, as well as the perception of the Baloch receiving an unfair deal from Islamabad. "What do you expect to happen?" says veteran politician Abdul Hayee Baloch of the National Party, who is a rare non-sardar in Balochistan's political landscape. "When people see that military operations have been going on against us since 1948, when they see their exploitation and when they see the military establishment unwilling to cede control to the people whose land it is, these hatreds will obviously grow." Some political activists in Quetta believe that this increasing radicalisation of the youth has reduced the influence of the mainstream political parties, and forced them into harsher political rhetoric lest they cede more ground to the radicals.

Despite the claims of India's involvement in Balochistan, Pakistani se-